



University of East London

**SCHOOL OF ARCHITECTURE, COMPUTING
AND ENGINEERING**

**Engineering
Postgraduate Courses**

EG7030

Applied Research & Engineering Practice I

MSc Dissertation Handbook

**Module Leader
(Dissertation Coordinator)
Dr Ali Abbas**

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MODULE GUIDE

2025 / 26

IMPORTANT DATES RELATING TO MSc RESEARCH DISSERTATION SUBMISSION DATES 2025/26

ACADEMIC YEAR	2025/26	2025/26	2025/26	2025/26
Session when dissertation submitted	SEMA	SEMB	SEM C	RESUBMISSION (2 ND OPPORTUNITY)
Deadline for PG Diploma students eligible to transfer to MSc to submit transfer request.	Already done	21/11/2026	20/02/2026	Already done
Deadline for choosing a topic and an appropriate supervisor. Students must register by this deadline quoting supervisor name on registration form.	Already done	21/11/2026	20/02/2026	Already done
Deadline for submission of 2 copies of the draft dissertation to the supervisor . Work must also be submitted to Turnitin on Moodle to check originality (you will be able to resubmit to Turnitin until the final deadline below).	05/01/2025	07/05/2026	01/09/2026	Second attempt should be carried out on the following semester immediately after the first attempt (e.g. if 1 st attempt was in Sem. A, then 2 nd attempt should be in Sem. B). For Re-sit, there might be a different submission deadline, so check Moodle and read email notifications, and check with Module Leader if in doubt.
Deadline for oral exam and feedback/corrections for the final copy of dissertation.	12/01/2026	14/05/2026	08/09/2026	
Deadline for submission of a final copy of dissertation to Turnitin on Moodle. Turn-it-in similarity percentage and a statement written by student confirming attendance at the research method classes must also be emailed to supervisor.	19/01/2026	21/05/2026	15/09/2026	
Date of Assessment Pre-Board & Board	Wk 26/01/2026	Wk 01/06/2026	Wk 21/09/2026	
Date of Award Board	Wk 02/02/2026	Wk 08/06/2026	Wk 28/09/2026	

TBC = To be confirmed

Wk = Week

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Module Specification

Module Title: Applied Research & Engineering Practice I	Module Code: EG7030 Level: 7 Credit: 60 ECTS credit: 30	Module Leader: Dr Ali Abbas
Pre-requisite: None		Pre-cursor: None
Co-requisite: None	Excluded combinations : None	Suitable for incoming study abroad? N
Location of delivery: UEL		
Summary of module for applicants: Applied Research skills are key to addressing engineering challenges and providing creative solutions. The module aims to provide students with an opportunity to explore a research topic in depth, with appropriate research methods, Interpret the results in an engineering context, provide critical discussion and conclusions, and compose a research dissertation. The students will undertake this in subject areas relevant to the programme they are enrolled on. It also allows them to plan and execute their work plan and manage their time as well as exercising their engineering judgment and applying principles of engineering practice. They are encouraged to experience engineering as problem solving, considering the systematic processes that engineers use to define and resolve problems.		
Main topics of study: - Students will select a research topic in consultation with an appropriate subject specialist supervisor. - Students are expected to develop a project proposal with a time management plan will be developed in liaison with the project supervisor. - Students are expected to use and integrate the knowledge and skills gained through the taught modules in MSc programmes (e.g. Civil, Structural Engineering). - Students are expected to develop communication and research methodology skills through Research Methods classes. - Students are encouraged to expand their knowledge and skills on engineering ethics and practice and to enhance key skills such as problem solving and synthesis of information to make valid judgements and reasoning.		
This module will be able to demonstrate at least one of the following examples/ exposures <i>(please tick one or more of the appropriate boxes, evidence will need to be provided later in this document)</i> Live, applied project ☒ Company/engagement visits ☐ Company/industry sector endorsement/badging/sponsorship/award ☒		
Learning Outcomes for the module <i>Code of Competencies</i> - Digital Proficiency - Code = (DP) - Industry Connections - Code = (IC)		

- *Emotional Intelligence Development - Code = (EID)*
- *Social Intelligence Development - Code = (SID)*
- *Physical Intelligence Development - Code = (PID)*
- *Cultural Intelligence Development - Code = (CID)*
- *Community Connections - Code = (CC)*
- *UEL Give-Back - Code = (UGB)*

At the end of this module, students will be able to:

Knowledge

1. Identify and apply appropriate theoretical framework to the chosen topic.
2. Demonstrate detailed knowledge of one chosen and highly specific area within the domain of their programme of study and communicate this knowledge through a written report.
3. Demonstrate knowledge of research methods appropriate for Masters level (i.e. Level7) research and to communicate this knowledge through a written report.

Thinking skills

4. Implement a piece of advanced research as formulated in the project proposal.
5. Competently and critically select appropriate research methods and tools for data collection and analysis. (DP)
6. Critically interpret the results in relation to existing knowledge.
7. Demonstrate critical self-reflection on the research process and suggest further developments.

Subject-based practical skills

8. Conduct an advanced search of literature and/or other appropriate sources.

Skills for life and work (general skills)

9. Prepare a detailed piece of work written in a scholarly fashion according to set guidelines.
10. Demonstrate the confidence and skills to manage research in a way that is consistent with both professional practice and the normal principles of research ethics. (IC)
11. Plan the production of an extended piece of work to meet a fixed delivery deadline. (EID)

Teaching/ learning methods/strategies used to enable the achievement of learning outcomes:

For on campus students:

Lectures to develop research method and communication skills.
Online continuous learning.
Independent study complimented by supervisor – student meetings. (SID)

Assessment methods which enable students to demonstrate the learning outcomes for the module; please define as necessary:

Written Submission (12,500 words)

Weighting:

100%

Learning Outcomes demonstrated:

1-11

Reading and resources for the module:

These must be up to date and presented in correct Harvard format unless a Professional Body specifically requires a different format

Core

UEL Moodle: Academic Integrity - Resources for Students→ (in particular: Academic Integrity Policy, Cite Them Right, Turnitin resources).

Bell, J. (2010) *Doing your research project*. 5th edn. Buckingham: Open University Press.

Hart, C. (1998) *Doing a literature review: Releasing the social science research imagination*. London: Sage Publications.

O'Leary, Z. (2017) *The essential guide to doing your research project*. 3rd edn. Sage Publications Ltd.

Swetnam, D. (2000) *Writing your dissertation*. 3rd edn. Oxford: How to Books. Pears, R. and

Shields, G. (2013) *Cite them right: the essential referencing guide*. 9th edn. Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan.

Recommended

Rudestam, K.E. and Newton, R.R. (2007) *Surviving your dissertation: a comprehensive guide to content and process*. London: Sage.

Sharp, J.A. and Howard, K. (2002) *The management of a student research project*. 3rd edn. Farnham: Gower Publishing Ltd.

Glasman-Deal, H. (2009) *Science research writing for non-native speakers of English*. London: Imperial College Press

Levin, P. (2008) *Excellent dissertation*. Maidenhead: Open University Press

Walliman, N. S. (2011) *Your research project: a step-by-step guide for the first-time researcher*. 3rd edn. London: Sage.

Farrell, P (2011) *Writing a built environment dissertation. Practical guidance and examples*. Chichester: John Wiley & Sons Ltd.

Provide evidence of how this module will be able to demonstrate at least one of the following examples/ exposures

Live, applied project

Data extracted for analysis and written research report can be from live projects in engineering field (e.g. civil, mechanical etc.)

Company/engagement visits N/A

Company/industry sector endorsement/badging/sponsorship/award

Invite guest speakers from industry to cover specialist areas in engineering such as health and safety, engineering ethics and professional practice, mental wealth etc. (IC)

Indicative learning and teaching time (10 hrs per credit):	Activity
1. Student/tutor interaction:	
18 hours	Research Methods classes
10 hours	Supervisory meetings
2. Student learning time:	
572 hours	
Total hours (1 and 2):	600 hours

1. Aim

Your MSc Dissertation project is a very important component of your Course here at UEL, not only in terms of the mark allocated to it but also from the valuable experience which you should gain from it. It is a significant piece of work of 60 credits and is undertaken individually on a topic related to your field of study. It is also related to the taught element of the programme and/or on the student's experience and interests. Students are given some flexibility in choosing a topic and are encouraged to think about it early, and to discuss their ideas with potential supervisors and the module leader. In order to ensure that you maximize the benefits of the project (and also to enable you to meet the submission deadline!) you should give it careful consideration.

This module aims to develop the student's research skills through investigating a complex problem, reviewing the state of the art and devising a suitable solution methodology in order to reach credible findings and conclusions. In particular, the dissertation project is aimed at improving the student's ability to evaluate the research results critically and not merely reporting them. Crucially also, the project will enhance key skills such as decision making, application of engineering judgement, communication skills, organisation and time management. Supervision is provided, but the students are expected to work largely independently and are expected to produce a dissertation of potentially publishable quality.

2. Research Method Classes

The module is supported by weekly research method classes, which are designed to help develop key research skills as well as scientific writing support. The attendance at these classes is mandatory and failure to attend them may lead to withdrawal from the module in accordance with UEL attendance and engagement policy. The lectures are designed to give the students an understanding of what is required of them in terms of output, planning and managing their work, literature review, critical analysis and

reflection, conclusions, referencing, academic integrity and plagiarism, presenting their work and the viva voce.

2.1. Research methods and dissertation writing skills

Students prepare a research proposal during the research methods workshop. The proposal sets out the problem and the methodology to be adopted and be a feasible project to carry out in the time available. It will be developed in liaison with the project supervisor, who will comment on the dissertation's worthiness as MSc standard.

2.2 The research methods workshops

The Research Methods Workshops will be conducted over the duration of the term and attendance is mandatory as per UEL attendance and engagement policy. They typically cover the following topics:

1	What is a dissertation? / Academic Style
2	Research Methodology
3	Library resources talk
4	Submitting a Proposal
5	Critical thinking , Critical Reading, Critical Writing
6	Speed Reading, Note Taking
7	Argumentation: Paragraph structure, argument and counterargument
8	Indirect citation: Paraphrasing Summarising
9	Referencing
10	From Proposal to completed Dissertation
11	Writing Introductions and Conclusions

12	Proofreading/Plenary
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3. Contact with supervisor

The supervisor role is to give guidance to the student as to the direction of the dissertation. The students will be encouraged to establish their own ideas and opinions from early on. The supervisor will comment and advise on the work as it progresses. However the work is very much the student's and so the student cannot expect direct help with content. Neither can the student expect the supervisor to 'mark' interim work as it appears.

3.1 The Log Book/ Reflective Journal

This is a document that the student uses to record the progress of their learning during the research period. This log book needs to be submitted with their final bound copy of dissertation.

The student should complete the log book to document research activities as well as reflecting on them. This includes the RM workshop, contact with the supervisor, related reading, any other discussions with fellow students, industry ..etc. At the end of each meeting with the supervisor, the log book page needs to be signed by the supervisor to confirm the meeting, progress and future work.

3.2 Dissertation Student–Supervisor contact

It is recommended that an agreement needs to be signed by students at the commencement of the dissertation project (see Appendix). The purpose of the contact is to give students the support they need to enable them to complete an acceptable dissertation within the timescale allowed. It is the **responsibility of the student** to contact their supervisor to discuss their research and ensure that their work progresses according to the plan that they had prepared in their research proposal. Regular contact of a minimum of 10 hours between the student-supervisor is a

requirement of the programme and a pre-requisite for submission of the dissertation. One or more members of the civil engineering and surveying field will supervise the dissertation work of each student. Students must undertake their research investigations at the Docklands Campus, unless work with an outside employer or authority is involved. Such cases will require prior agreement of the module leader and an external supervisor must be identified who will liaise with the module leader to confirm the authenticity of the student's dissertation work.

Students **will not be allowed to carry out their research project outside the UK** unless in exceptional circumstances (e.g. if the supervisor has external partners abroad and thinks adequate academic support will be provided there). In such circumstances, prior written agreement of **both** the supervisor and the programme leader **must be sought before** the project commences. Carrying a research project aboard **must never** be about a student wishing to go back home and tailor the project to suit this aim. This prohibition is put in place to enable the student to have adequate access to campus facilities such as the library, laboratories, software ..etc. It is also aimed at ensuring the quality of the research project and the MSc degree. If there are personal circumstances requiring the student to stay aboard during their dissertation, they are advised to consider taking an intermission of studies or deferment until their circumstances improve.

4. Selection of dissertation supervisor and topic

Before progressing to the dissertation, students registered on the MSc are expected to have passed the majority of the taught modules particularly in the subject area of the proposed dissertation.

Deadlines for choosing a topic and an appropriate supervisor are published in advance to give the students sufficient time to contact their potential supervisor and agree a topic. Please refer to the “**important dates list**” provided at the beginning of this handbook. Students **must register by the specified deadline** quoting the name of their supervisor on the registration form. Any registration form without a supervisor

name **will not be processed**. For the **latest list of supervisors**, their research interests and contact details, the staff section on the School website should be consulted.

Students who wish to complete their dissertations over semester C (summer period) are advised to contact their supervisors and agree their supervision **well before** the deadline. Semester C is available for research only in the case that it has been agreed by the research supervisor.

If you are having difficulties in finding a supervisor, please let the module leader know as early as possible.

5. UEL Plus

There is a UEL plus page for CEM011 MSc Dissertation module which will be used to support learning. In particular, news items and lectures will all be uploaded to UEL Plus. E-mails will also be used to update students from time to time. Students must ensure that they **check their UEL e-mail account regularly**. Private e-mail addresses will **not** be used.

On UEL Plus main page (this is the one you see once you log on to UEL Plus and before clicking on CEM011 page) there is a page at the top of the list entitled **Academic Integrity - Resources for Students**. Students should read carefully through the information documents provided.

6. ASSESSMENT

UEL now has a standardised assessment framework. Detailed information about this is given to all students. The assessment for this module will be based upon a written report, which will be assessed both orally and as text by two markers (**max. 12500 words**). In accordance with the framework, students **MUST** obtain a **minimum of 50% overall** in order to pass this module. The dissertation element (including oral assessment) is worth **100%** for this module.

6.1. Oral Examination and Final Submission

The oral examination takes place following the handing in of 2 **draft copies** of the dissertation. Following the exam, corrections/suggestions for improvement will be

made as appropriate which the student must implement and then submit a **final hard-bound copy** with a **CD** containing the entire dissertation. The **portfolio** of the work leading to the submission of the dissertation and/or the **log book must** also be submitted.

In addition, a **summary** of the **Turnitin originality report** must be submitted as well (this should simply quote the **ID number** generated by Turnitin software for your submission, number of words and the originality report % - only **print and submit** the **first two pages of originality report** - please do **NOT** submit the **full** report itself as this will be checked by your supervisor using your online submission).

Students must be aware that **failure to submit** the **final hard-bound copy** to the Help Desk by the deadline advertised will result in a **zero** mark awarded for the whole module (regardless of the mark awarded at the oral examination).

6.2. Marking Scheme

University of East London
School of Architecture, Computing and Engineering
Assessment of Engineering MSc research Project

Supervisor Name: _____ Assessor Name: _____

Student Name: _____ Student ID: _____

Project Title: _____

Continuous Assessment	Maximum mark %	Mark Obtained
Subject Development	10	
Effort and competency	10	
Subtotal A	20	

Project Assessment	Maximum mark %	Mark Obtained
Literature Review	10	
Research Method	10	
Critical Assessment	25	
Conclusions	10	
Presentation	5	
Subtotal B	60	

Oral Examination	Maximum mark %	Mark Obtained
Knowledge of Subject Area	10	
Defence of Thesis	10	
Subtotal C	20	

Collation of Marks

Assessment	Subtotal A	Subtotal B	Subtotal C
From Supervisor			
From Assessor			
Agreed MARK			

Final Project Mark%

7. Health and Safety

It is our policy to do all that is reasonably practicable to ensure the health, safety and welfare of all students and staff, as well as people who may visit any of our premises and be affected by our work activities. As such we comply with all relevant health and safety legislative requirements.

On the programme we will provide safe systems for working, a safe environment for teaching and learning, adequate health and welfare arrangements and facilities, and the elimination of risks associated with health and safety. Full details can be found on UEL Plus. [All ACE Students](#)→[ACE Information](#)→[University Documents](#)

All student conducting laboratory based projects are required to conform to all relevant Health and Safety requirements when using these facilities. This includes a duty of care to themselves and other users together with the use of provided protective equipment.

7.1 Personal Protective Equipment (PPE)

Students are required to wear suitable Personal Protective Equipment (PPE) whenever they are working or testing within the laboratories. This includes steel toe capped footwear (which the student must provide) in addition to eye & ear protection as well as protective gloves (these will be provided where required). Failure to comply with this requirement will result in students being asked by technical staff to vacate the area until such time as they have suitable footwear. Note that such requirement to wear and use PPE constitutes an **absolute minimum** requirement.

7.1 Risk Assessment

It is the responsibility of **all** students undertaking laboratory work to familiarise themselves with all relevant health and safety requirements. **Risk Assessments** must also that must be undertaken prior to starting their work (see Appendix for details).

8. Academic Integrity

It is essential that the students are fully aware of UEL policy on plagiarism and collusion and that they are able to quote and reference others work correctly. On UEL Plus main page there is a page at the top of the list entitled **Academic Integrity - Resources for Students**. Students should read carefully through the information documents provided, particularly the ones on:

Academic Integrity - Resources for Students→Academic Integrity Policy and UEL Assessment Regulations

Academic Integrity - Resources for Students→Plagiarism & Collusion - A Guide for Students

Academic Integrity - Resources for Students→Turnitin resources

Full details on the procedure for submission to Turnitin can be found at:

http://www.uel.ac.uk/uelconnect/learning_technologies/uel_plus/turnitin.htm

Where a file is very large it may not be possible to submit it to Turnitin. In such cases the file should be edited to remove figures and photos, which take up a lot of space, and the remaining text, which will be much less space consuming, submitted.

8.1 References

All reference sources that have been used directly in the report must be included in a list after the Discussion and Conclusions sections in a separate section titled "References". A full description of each reference must be given so that the reference can be easily traced by anyone else in the future.

References should be given in compliance with the Harvard system of referencing as adopted by UEL. Full details of this can be obtained by visiting the Library and Learning Services website at:

<http://www.uel.ac.uk/lis/support/harvard.htm>

References should be listed in alphabetical order by the name of the main author. Where references to Internet resources or URL's are given, these should be accompanied by a statement of the date on which they were visited.

8.2 Bibliography

The bibliography should follow a similar format to the references section but is to include a list of references for material which has provided background reading to the work but not been cited directly in the text.

8.3 Appendices

In many instances appendices may be used to accommodate information which is not sufficiently important to include in the main report but will contain data that is useful to supplement the text of the main report.

Examples of such information might be include copies of complete design software output files or tables of complete sets of readings taken during laboratory work which have been presented more conveniently in graphs or tables in the main report.

Appendices should be named A, B, C etc. for ease of cross-referencing.

8.4 Access to the Construction Information Service (CIS)

CIS provides a downloadable library of high quality technical references which is fully searchable. CIS is available as one of the UEL Library databases.

In order to access the Service, you will need to go to the list of Databases on the UEL Library page and then find the Construction Information Service on the Database list.

The relevant URL is:

<http://www.uel.ac.uk/lis/resources/databaselistc.htm>

You will need an Athens account to access the service.

The following URL explains Athens accounts:

<http://www.uel.ac.uk/lis/resources/athens.htm>

An Athens account is automatically generated for students and will be sent to your UEL email address once you have enrolled.

If you have any problems accessing your Athens account you will need to contact the Athens Administrator through the [Ask A Librarian via email](#) form.

9. Research Methods Lectures (1)

9.1 Good Research

- Data — this is the basis of arguments and findings you make
- References —others' work and findings which are relevant to your work
- Analysis — manipulation and interpretation of data and how it relates to others' work and findings

Other Qualities relevant to Dissertation

- Your work should have both breadth and depth
- Critical assessment (of your work and others) is key to a successful research project
- Clarity is essential
- Good structure
- Consistent (e.g. conclusions match aims, referencing style)
- You can develop/amend proposal as your work progresses
- Avoid Plagiarism!

Choosing your topic

- Need a willing supervisor of course
- Supervisors (check staff page on the School's website)
- Can choose own topic subject to supervisor's agreement
- Contact as many supervisors as you can starting with those closest to your area of interest (but do not limit your choices too narrowly)
- Ask yourself three basic questions
 1. Can I get data (If relevant)?
 2. Can I get references?
 3. What can I add?
- When you have one topic you are satisfied with write it into a proposal
- Agree topic and proposal with supervisor

Some tips for doing your dissertation

- Make as much time available as possible (15/30 hrs per week is recommended)
- Plan your chapter layout from early on (e.g. introduction, literature review, method, ..etc) and create folders with matching names so that you can always add things in the right place and write up as your work progresses
- Always introduce a chapter by stating where we're going
- Always have a summary of the chapter by stating where we've been
- Make a diary of time available and what you plan to do with time
- Make the most out of the supervisor-student relationship
- Levels of contact (Email, phone, meetings etc)
- During staff holidays seek other help
- Conclusion - short and reflect what you've done

Planning

- Make Dissertation Diary (e.g. computer-based) from now and up to the end of your dissertation.
- Match with current normal schedule and insert into diary the number of hours available daily for the dissertation.
- Examine the pattern of time available.
- Once proposal ready insert large activities e.g. lab. testing, computer programming, literature review, ..etc.
- Make changes to your diary as you proceed but keep record of old ones
- Insert your thoughts each week e.g. major problem getting program to run, everything going well.
- Make observations about how you feel e.g. confident, scared
- Towards the end of the dissertation read through entire diary to get a feel of how it has gone.
- Use the diary to make corrections to your thinking about good planning for the future.
- Within Evaluation make any key explanations/observations e.g. originally my dissertation aim was to get a full working version but because of have settled for a proto-type I would suggest that problems with might be more common than generally thought and

10. Research Methods Lectures (2)

10.1 Developing your Research Questions

Having chosen a question for your study you should divide up this into four or five sub-questions.

For example:

Question

Following the development of E-newspapers, what are the prospects for the Newspaper industry in France?

Sub-questions

What is an E-Newspaper?

What is the present condition of the Newspaper industry in France?

What is French culture like with regard technology?

What evidence is there that people will read E-Newspapers?

The sub-questions will form your Chapters so start to write down what will be included under each chapter/section:

What is an E-Newspaper?

Internet

Other E-Businesses (e.g. Amazon)

Example of on-line papers (www.GuardianUnlimited.com)

What is French culture like with regard technology?

How many people in France have a phone/mobile/computer?

What is the level of on-line shopping in France?

Interview with some well-chosen French people

This is the time to see a supervisor

Things to think about

1. The Title

- Make it appropriate
- Make it succinct

2. Aims

An aim is a general statement of intent describing what your project will achieve.

- You get these from the sub-questions

Example from above

To investigate whether or not French society is a technological one

To examine if French people are likely to become E-newspaper readers

Etc

3. Objectives

An objective is a more specific statement about how the general aims of the project will be achieved.

- You get these from listing the activities you will do in carrying out the project

Example from above

To conduct a survey of 20 French people with regard their technological and reading lives

To visit a Parisian family for two weeks and study how they live

Etc

4. Methodology

- A statement as to how you plan to do the research
- A justification for that plan

Example from above

In this essay the prospects for the newspaper industry in France is examined. To do this, both theoretical and practical perspectives will be used. From a theoretical perspective the subject is multi-disciplinary incorporating: cultural studies, technology and media. Major journals in these areas have been used to examine both the quantity and content of these works. Two major journals (recommended to by my supervisor) were taken from each of these three areas and read everything relevant published since 1998. This date was chosen as the topic is clearly a dynamic one and thus information has a limited 'sell-by-date'. These were used as the bedrock of the theoretical understanding though this was supplemented with web, newspaper and book references. References from journals were used as I believe the intellectual quality and rigour of these are unique.

From a practical perspective there was a need to collect data with regards to the likelihood of French people reading E-newspapers. To this end both primary and secondary data was gathered. Sixteen French people were interviewed. These were chosen by trying to select a range of individuals that cross age, gender and educational boundaries. In addition some secondary data was obtained from the French Ministry of Culture.

An analysis was carried out on what the theoretical perspectives suggested against data collected to see if there any major differences.

Exercise

For your dissertation topic detail: a title, the objectives, the aims and the methodology.

11. Research Methods Lectures (3)

11.1 Handling Data

There are four basic issues about collecting data:

1. Who shall I ask?
2. How shall I ask them?
3. What shall I ask them?
4. What shall I do with the answers?

Who shall I ask?

1. Define the categories you wish to distinguish against each other e.g.
Male/Female
2. ONLY choose categories that you feel might produce difference – you should be looking for interesting results remember!
3. In each category count the different members
e.g. If age (say 4 – Under 20, Under 40, Under 60, Over 60) and gender (2) and multiply together and this will give the total number of categories and the different groups
8 - females under 20, females under 40, females under 60, females over 60, males under 20, males under 40, males under 60, females over 60.
4. Statistics show that you need at least 5 people in each category so you must ask can you find five such people. Can you find five females under 60? Etc
5. If you cannot then go back to step 1.

How shall I ask them?

1. Choice of techniques – questionnaires, interviews, observations
2. Mode of asking – face-to-face, e-mail, website, letters
3. Choose which is most appropriate and you think will work
4. Beware – returns from questions are often quite small

What shall I ask them?

1. Define the types of questions you wish to ask? e.g. Taste in music, Money spent on music, etc
2. Formulate questions
3. Try not to have too many questions
4. Try to stick to things you suspect will produce interesting results when looking across the categories of people you got from Who shall I ask
5. Design your questions and how to ask them

What shall I do with the answers?

BEFORE GOING TO GET YOUR DATA ALWAYS IMAGINE THE TYPES OF ANSWER YOU WILL GET AND HOW YOU WILL PROCESS THEM

E.G

I will compare the gender differences in taste in music and represent it as a pie chart with pie slices as the types of music

I will draw a histogram of ages against amount of money spent on clothes last year

Only when you have completed all four questions should you collect your data

Exercise

For your dissertation/essay think of the data you need.

12. Research Methods (4)

12.1 Finish your work

When you have what you believe to be all the text in place for your work then this is the time to perform the Final Edit. This is not just spell-checking as many think. It consists of many things the most important of which are:

1. Final check for padding
2. Rewrite the Abstract
3. Final choice of title
4. Spell and Grammar check
5. References, notes and Bibliography check
6. Check clarity, coherence and ease to read through (ask a friend to read)
7. Cross referencing
8. Check and re-check for Plagiarism!
9. Word count
10. Print off
11. Binding

1. Final check for padding

Read through your work and ask the 'So what?' question i.e. do I need this? Remove bits that seem unnecessary

2. Rewrite the Abstract

Having completed the work and read your own work through, this is then the best time to sum up the what, how and why of your work in an Abstract.

3. Final choice of title

Having completed the work and read your own work through, this is then the best time to decide on an appropriate, clever and concise title.

4. Spell and Grammar check

Spell and grammar check against the correct (e.g. English U.K) dictionary.

5. Reference, notes and Bibliography check

- Perform a search (e.g. for '(') and compile a list of all the reference keys given in your work
- Check all these exist in your reference list
- Check there are no references that are in the list that are NOT used
- The bibliographic references should be fully given and books etc that you have used as basis for your reading in the preparation of your dissertation but NOT used directly
- Check all quotes in your work to check page numbers given

6. Friendly read through

Exchange your dissertation with a friend and read each others through noting:

- When its not clear
- When there is a grammar or textual error
- Ideas for how to make it more attractive

Beware of collusion and plagiarism. Exchange only after BOTH of you have your dissertation ready for checking.

7. Cross Referencing

Go through each chapter and add phrases like 'As we saw in Chapter 2...' (Backward reference) or 'As we will see in Chapter 5...' (Forward reference). This is very important to make sure you have an integrated document and not just a series of unrelated chapters.

8. Check and re-check for Plagiarism

Plagiarism is taken very seriously at UEL. A clear definition of the types of plagiarism can be found in UEL Guidelines on Plagiarism. In addition you have examples of the types of activity and action likely to result in plagiarism in your UEL Dissertation Study Guide (see Appendix).

Once some evidence of plagiarism is found your case will be passed to the UEL Plagiarism Panel. The Panel will operate under its own guidelines but will basically consider the merits and circumstances of the given case and an appropriate punishment.

9. Word Count

Perform a word count and check that it conforms to the stated limit.

10. Print off

Print a page at a time to ensure tidy print. Margins should be as stated (see Appendix). Headings should not be at bottom of page. Page numbers in right place etc

11. Binding

Print whole thing on quality paper and send off for binding. Then you can prepare yourself for the viva.

13. Appendices

- 13.1 Appendix A: Cover Sheet Format**
- 13.2 Appendix B: Dissertation Format and Layout**
- 13.3 Appendix C: Thesis Binders contact information**
- 13.4 Appendix D: Hazard Assessment Form**
- 13.5 Appendix E: Dissertation Student-Supervisor Contact**
- 13.6 Appendix F: UEL Policy on the use of Turnitin¹**
- 13.7 Appendix G: To Catch a Plagiarist**
- 13.8 Appendix H: Research Ethics Approval Form**

COVER SHEET FORMAT

<TITLE IN CAPITALS, CENTERED IN BOLD FONT 16>

By

<Your Name & Surname>

<Your Student Number>

*A dissertation submitted in partial fulfilment
of the requirements for the degree of:*

*Master of Science
in
<Your pathway e.g. Civil Engineering>*

Submitted to the
University of East London
On

<Date>

Supervisor: <Your supervisor name>

DISSERTATION LAYOUT

The following is intended to assist with writing up and students are not obliged to follow it if they wish to use a different format. It is also meant to compliment the guidelines given in the Research Method Classes and not to replace them.

A typical format for a dissertation would be:

Title page

Abstract

This should not be more than 300 words.

Acknowledgements

Table of Contents

List of Tables

List of Figures

1. Introduction

This should include background to the problem and the objectives of the work.

2. Literature Review

This is a critical review of existing literature and not merely a description.

3. Methodology

4. More Chapters as necessary

5. Results and Discussion

The results should be described in logical order. It is a common failing to assume that the reader knows the project as well as you do. Refer appropriately to figures or tables and emphasize significant results.

The discussion should attempt to tie together the results, what they indicate in the broader context (with reference to relevant literature), the extent to which the original aims have been satisfied and what future work is suggested. This section is extremely important and deserves careful attention.

6. Conclusions and Recommendations

Summarise the main conclusions of the work undertaken in logical sequence. Make recommendations for future work.

7. References

Use the Harvard system. Refer to "Cite Them Right" document for further information.

Appendix I

Appendix II

DISSERTATION FORMAT

Before printing off your final version of your dissertation please set up the following margins

Left Margin = 4 cm

Top right & Bottom = 2 cm

1.5 spacing

Please allow 1 extra gap after main title

Title and Sub title should be in Bold

Title = 16pt

Sub title = 14pt

Don't start your title or sub-title at the bottom of the page always go to new page.

Font size 12pt Font type Arial (preferably)

Check for grammars and spelling in UK English

Give reference to all graphs, tables and pictures.

Do not forget to submit your work to **TURNITIN** and enclose findings from the TURNITIN to your dissertation before submission to the Help Desk **on time (only print and submit the first two pages of originality report** - please do **NOT** submit the **full** report itself as this will be checked by your supervisor using your online submission).

THESIS BINDERS CONTACT INFORMATION

Avalon Associates have been providing thesis binding services to our MSc students for several years now. Their contact details are as follows:

Tel: 01245 468706 or 01245 462685

Mob.: 07768 955822

Email: avalonassociates@yahoo.co.uk or avalon.assoc@virgin.net

Web: www.avalon-assoc.co.uk

You can either e-mail them your dissertation or leave a hard copy at HelpDesk for them to collect. Always **allow sufficient time** before the deadline for the binding to take place.

SCHOOL OF ARCHITECTURE, COMPUTING AND ENGINEERING (ACE)

PROJECT / RESEARCH HAZARD ASSESSMENT FORM

Name & ID:
Supervisor:
Project title:

Programme:
Project Location:

Brief Description of Project:

Nature of Possible Hazards : Note **ANY** hazards which are likely to be encountered during the project, if none, enter NONE:

FALLING OBJECTS (note items falling from small heights can pose injury hazard to your feet and extremities)

LIFTING OF HEAVY ITEMS (risk of injury to back and feet/extremities)

TRIP HAZARDS ON THE FLOOR

WORKING IN CONFINED SPACE

WORKING ALONE (never work alone without adequate supervision by a trained and competent person and always ensure that someone is nearby to assist in an emergency)

ELECTRICAL (e.g. equipment operating at voltages > 1000 V, working on exposed circuits with voltages > 50 V)

RADIATION (e.g. X-ray, Microwave , restricted areas).

CHEMICAL (e.g. toxic, volatile, explosive, carcinogenic)

LASER (all /any Laser , regardless of class)

MOVING CRANES/MACHINERY (e.g. working in restricted areas containing with moving cranes or mobile robots)

BIOLOGICAL (e.g. biological materials requiring containment)

OTHER

Any potential hazards should be discussed with your supervisor / director of studies, together with the correct safety procedures to be adopted to minimise their effect. Give further details where necessary or for any queries.

Date:

Signature of Student:

Signature of Supervisor/Director of Research:

Signature of ACE H&S Coordinator:

DISSERTATION STUDENT-SUPERVISOR CONTACT

The following Agreement will be signed by Students at the Commencement of the Dissertation.

1. The purpose of the Dissertation Student-Supervisor Contact is to give students the support they need to enable them to complete an acceptable Dissertation within the timescale allowed.
2. It is the responsibility of the student to contact their Supervisor in accordance with the Scheduled Timetable to discuss their research and ensure that their work progresses according to the plan that they had prepared in their Research Proposal
3. Regular contact of a minimum of 10 hours between the Student and Supervisor is a requirement of the programme and a pre-requisite for submission of the Dissertation.
4. A record of this contact will be kept and may be referred to at the Assessment Board if a student's Dissertation is discussed.
5. Students will be required to submit written drafts of parts of their Dissertation at times agreed with their Supervisor and submit their dissertation by the deadline.

I HAVE READ AND AGREE TO THESE CONDITIONS

STUDENT NAME

STUDENT ID

SIGNATURE DATE

POLICY ON THE USE OF TURNITIN WITHIN UEL

Rationale

Turnitin is an internet-based text matching service that has been developed by a commercial company. It is used, under license, by most UK Universities, including the University of East London. Work that is submitted to Turnitin generates a Turnitin Originality report, showing which parts of it have been reproduced from which sources. The system compares submissions to material that is to be found: on the world-wide web; in its database of previous submissions; and in its growing number of databases of published articles. You should not assume that a Turnitin Originality report with a low similarity index is evidence that the piece of work concerned is free from plagiarism.

This policy sets out how we use the service in connection with student work.

Our Policy

- 1 We recognise the educational desirability that all of our students should enjoy the opportunity to self-submit their work to Turnitin (before submitting for assessment). We also recognise that Turnitin Originality Reports will sometimes assist in the identification of plagiarised work submitted for assessment.
- 2 We will make Turnitin available to all of our students by way of our virtual learning environment (UELPlus) and we will encourage them to use it to improve their referencing skills.
- 3 All students will be given the opportunity to make multiple submissions of their written work to Turnitin.
- 4 All students will be advised, at the point of enrolment, that their work will be made available to third parties (such as Turnitin) for specified purposes, by way of a clause to be added to the Student Contract (the proposed clause, as suggested by Turnitin UK and JISCPAS, is set out in Annex I) and will be referred to Turnitin's Questions and Answers for Students¹.
- 5 A Module Leader may decide, in accordance with the policy of the appropriate School, that all student submissions for a particular component of assessment should be submitted to Turnitin, provided that the relevant Module Guide includes a notice to that effect.
- 6 All postgraduate research students will be required to submit their dissertations to Turnitin.
- 7 Where Turnitin submission is required of work that will contribute to summative assessment and the student fails to submit, s/he will be awarded a mark of 0 for the component in question.
- 8 An Originality Report should never be advanced as the sole reason for suspecting that a piece of work is plagiarised, because the judgement as to whether work is plagiarised must always be an academic judgement.

¹ We will publish guidance (for staff and for students) on the interpretation of Turnitin Originality Reports and we will publish advice on what to do in the event that the Turnitin service is not available in the period immediately before an assessment deadline.

When you submit work to us for assessment it may be necessary for us to make or allow third parties to make copies. Clause 4 of the Student Declaration gives us permission to do this subject to restrictions. There are three reasons this may be necessary.

First, in order to allow assessment of your work it may be necessary to copy it. This may be the case when external examiners are involved, when a piece of work is to be assessed by more than one assessor/examiner or if the assessor needs to mark the work and we need to keep a clean copy.

The second and third reasons for making copies of your submitted work are both related to plagiarism. In order to protect our students against unfair competition we need to ensure that our students are not submitting work which has copied or plagiarised other work or which is not substantially their own work. This can be done by making an electronic copy and comparing it with a database of earlier works and other works available from various sources. A copy made for this purpose will only be kept if that comparison alerts us to the need to consider the work more closely.

The databases - that allow us to check that plagiarised works are not being submitted - function well only if those databases are well maintained and current. We may provide a copy of your work to the third party providers who maintain such databases.

Full details on the procedure for submission to Turnitin can be found at:

http://www.uel.ac.uk/uelconnect/learning_technologies/uel_plus/turnitin.htm

Where a file is very large it may not be possible to submit it to Turnitin. In such cases the file should be edited to remove figures and photos, which take up a lot of space, and the remaining text, which will be much less space consuming, submitted.

If you have any questions about TurnItIn, you should go to “UELPlus – Student Support” at: www.uel.ac.uk/elearning/uelpus/student/index.htm



To catch a plagiarist

The chase is thrilling, but prevention is better than cure, says Sally Feldman

There's a new blood sport on Britain's campuses. It's got everything: the thrill of the chase, the lust for blood and the satisfaction of the kill. Its high season is exam time, and its name is plagiarism.

At this very moment, all over the country, dedicated academic sleuths are in hot pursuit of equally determined student copyists and cheats.

It is a developing battle. New advances in online technologies have made it easier for students to cheat. They can download existing essays from the internet, commission someone to write one bespoke, or develop more personal strategies. One student simply borrowed his flatmate's computer and then copied, pasted and submitted the essays as his own. It was, of course, the hapless computer owner who was penalised for plagiarism.

But the pursuers can retaliate with their own state-of-the-art technology. Turnitin software is able to identify any text that appears on external webpages, as well as its own database. It can then produce a report that highlights the identical sections of text, the source and the percentage copied.

It does have its limitations though. Electronic source-checkers are useful only for text-based work, so they're no help when you're dealing with artefacts. A fine example of concept burglary still wobbles proudly in our registry department – a plaster figure of the footballer Pelé that was once handed in as ceramics coursework. Underneath, ineptly scratched out, three telltale words are still discernible: "Made in Taiwan".

Fashion is a trade with a long tradition of copying and some students start early. Last year, one third-year handed in a dress that was way beyond her usual level of skill. A member of the University of Westminster registry was dispatched to Oxford Street to match the garment and tracked it down in Warehouse. "She could at least have nicked something decent from Armani," was the pained reaction from the course leader.

Fashion copiers can be pursued and caught. But how do the great plagiarist hunters even begin to track down their quarry in the jungles of art and design? Unmade beds, dead cows, flickering gallery lights and live runners are not copies: they are ironic statements, poststructuralist reflections adding layers of questioning to the very concept of the original.

The plagiarist is an even more elusive prey in music. George Harrison may have had to pay up a few years ago after a court recognised the striking similarity between *My Sweet Lord* and The Chiffons' hit *He's So Fine*. But that's a lot more straightforward than establishing who owns the copyright to a traditional folk song or to the hundreds of thousands of blues-based tunes all sharing the same 12-bar formation. And these days, with so many students indulging in DJ wizardry and the intricacies of scratching and sampling, artistic swiping and mixing of stolen phrases can hardly be categorised as plagiarism.

But the hunters do have their victories. Senior common rooms up and down the land echo with proud stories of success in nailing the sly, the stupid, the cunning and the most ingenious cheats. A colleague told me with great glee how he had discovered that one of our students had commissioned essays to be written on her behalf by posting assignment briefs online at RentACoder.com. Sadly for the student, she'd included links to her coursework briefs on our website, and was swiftly hunted down.

On another occasion, a student at a northern university included the name of a friend at Westminster among those who had helped him with his dissertation. It turned out that both students had submitted the same essay and were investigated by a joint committee from both institutions. There must have been some rubbing of hands by the academics who cracked that case.

Indeed, Turnitin and other devices have become such seductive tools for detection that some academics have become

quite obsessed with their power to track down even quite mild misdemeanours, in much the same way that Victorian schoolmasters would search out the slightest hints of masturbation among their boyhood charges.

As Michel Foucault elegantly explained in *The History of Sexuality*, it's all too easy for the game itself to become the point: "The pleasure that comes of exercising a power that questions, monitors, watches, spies, searches out, palpates, brings to light; and on the other hand, the pleasure that kindles at having to evade this power, flee from it, fool it, or travesty it." What results, he argues, is not a scaling down of the forbidden activity, but an escalation, dancing in "perpetual spirals of power and pleasure".

Turnitin encourages this kind of spiralling because it's impersonal. It allows you to spot the offence regardless of the identity of the student, so that the pursuit itself takes over; not so much Turnitin but Turn'em in.

There is, of course, only one way out of this game, one way to escape the spiral. Instead of starting with the act of detection, we should throw all our resources into ensuring that students don't contemplate plagiarism. That is why our academic integrity policy at Westminster recommends a change of emphasis from "offence" to "good practice" and from "catching" to "educating". Some are nervous that such an approach may seem to condone poor scholarship and dilute standards. But at least it may deter the overzealous from actually enjoying the chase.

Of course, in the days when lecturers actually knew their students, they could recognise when a piece of work was out of character. But with swelling class sizes on so many courses, that kind of intimacy is becoming more difficult. That's why, all too often, personal understanding is being replaced by an inhuman slab of software.

Sally Feldman is dean of media, arts and design, University of Westminster.

9 July 2009 *Times Higher Education* 27

Senior common rooms up and down the land echo with proud stories of success in nailing the sly, the stupid, the cunning and the most ingenious cheats

UNIVERSITY OF EAST LONDON
School of Architecture, Computing and Engineering
Undergraduate / Masters Projects.

**APPLICATION FOR THE APPROVAL OF RESEARCH ACTIVITIES INVOLVING
HUMAN PARTICIPANTS**
YOU MUST NOT CONDUCT RESEARCH WITH PEOPLE UNDER THE AGE OF 18.

1.	Student Number: _____ Year: _____ Semester: _____ Programme: _____
2.	Purpose of research? Describe the aim and objectives of your research briefly. How will you collect your data? (e.g. interview, questionnaire, observation etc.)
3.	Nature of participants (general characteristics e.g University students, staff at client's premises, etc.)? Number of participants (approximately)? How will you identify them? Where will the research take place (e.g. on University premises, at the Client's premises, on-line etc.)?
4.	Probable duration of the research? From (starting date): _____ To (finishing date): _____
5.	What are the possibilities that your participants might suffer harm or experience discomfort (either physical or emotional) as a result of your research? If there is any, what is the nature of the harm or discomfort? What precautions will you take to prevent your participants from suffering harm or experiencing discomfort?
6.	DECLARATION I agree to abide by the University of East London's Code of Good Practice in Research (http://www.uel.ac.uk/ga/manual/codeofpractice.htm) when carrying out my research. Personal data will be treated in the strictest confidence and not passed on to third parties without the written consent of the subject.

The nature of my investigation and any possible risks will be fully explained to all participants. They will be informed that

- (a) they are not obliged to participate in my research nor are they obliged to give reasons why they should not participate and
- (b) They may withdraw from my research at any time, without disadvantaging themselves and without having to give reasons.

NAME OF STUDENT:

Signed: _____

SUPERVISOR:

Signed: _____

Date: _____